

1930–1939

SHIMMERING GOWNS

At the end of the 1920s the relatively brief reign of the short evening dress was over. The fashionable sipped cocktails in long, figure-hugging gowns that sometimes left little to the imagination. Frequently cut along the lines of swimwear, dresses were often precariously suspended from the thinnest of shoulder straps and left the backs of their wearers completely exposed. Shiny, fluid fabric – such as satin and lamé – was cut on the bias and manufactured into confections that clung to the body. If dieting did not have the desired effect, women could buy foundations made of the new “tu-way stretch” materials to achieve the all-important smooth, unbroken line. Women stepped out in whites, off-whites, silver, gold, and shades of apricot, peach, and salmon – if they were not wearing black.



1933

Lamé dress American designer Jessie Franklin Turner used lamé to great effect in this bias-cut evening gown, making the wearer look as if sprayed with liquid metal. Unusually, the dress has long sleeves but still exposes glimpses of the upper body.



1937

Fashionable apricot The base colour of French designer Jeanne Lanvin's evening dress is accentuated with silver sequin embroidery. The simply but elegantly cut dress is made of a synthetic material, which was used even in couture houses.



1938

Silk fringing It looks as if widening bands of fringing have been applied to this clinging rayon dress by French designer Madeleine Vionnet. Closer inspection reveals that individual silk threads have been sewn on to the dress; each forms two drops of fringe.